

Indian Writing in English

INTRODUCTION



Definition and Condition

Indian English literature (IEL), or Indian Writing in English (IWE), is the body of work by writers in India who write in the English language and whose native or co-native language could be one of the numerous languages of India.

Indian Writing in English is a result of the British Imperial Rule

The English language had to be adequately adopted and adapted by the Indian people to be able to express the reality of the Indian situation.

Indians had to have sufficient knowledge and skill to use the English language to express themselves.

Macauley's *Minutes*

“It is impossible for us, with our limited means, to attempt to educate the body of the people. We must at present do our best to form a class who may be interpreters between us and the millions whom we govern; **a class of persons, Indian in blood and colour, but English in taste, in opinions, in morals, and in intellect.** To that class we may leave it to refine the vernacular dialects of the country, to enrich those dialects with terms of science borrowed from the Western nomenclature, and to render them by degrees fit vehicles for conveying knowledge to the great mass of the population.”

Though India was under the British rule, still, English was adopted by the Indians as a language of understanding and awareness, education and literary expression with an important means of communication amongst various people of dissimilar religions.

Locating IWE Historically

Introduction of English language into schools and universities

Thomas Babington or Lord Macaulay's *Minute Upon Indian Education* was introduced in 1833

It provided for the introduction of English as a medium of instruction with the claim that “the English tongue would be the most useful for our native subjects.”

English was introduced in educational institutions, Courts and offices, displacing the traditional use of Arabic and Sanskrit as a mode of communication and documentation.

The English Education Act 1835 was a legislative Act of the Council of India, that gave effect to a decision in 1835 by Lord William Bentinck, then Governor-General of the British East India Company.

Lord William Bentinck announced in 1835 that the government would “favour English Language alone” henceforth and would move towards “a knowledge of English literature and Science through the medium of English language alone.”

Continued

The Wood Dispatch of 1854 proclaimed the establishment of the Universities at Bombay, Madras and Calcutta and thereafter made the English language accessible to students, professors and also the officials of Government offices.

To begin with the introduction of English at these levels had some interesting repercussions.

This form of English was called “Babu English” because it resulted out of a forced encounter between the British English language and the unwilling Babu. The ‘art and craft’ and discomfort with which they used the language in the offices in course became a matter of derision.

Here is another in much the same strain :—

“HONOURED AND MUCH RESPECTED SIR,—With due respect and humble submission, I beg to bring to your kind notice that for a long days, I have not the fortune to pay you a respect, or not to have your mental or daily welfare, therefore my request that you will be kind enough to show me some mercy and thankfulness, by pending some few lines to your wretched son and thereby highly oblige. In accordance by your verbal order, I am still lingering for your hopeful words, which I cannot put out from my memory or think not to be disappointed by you.

“Those words are not my fancyless imaginations, but a desire of ardent hope that I shall be patronize by you, and that patronism and gratitude are ever remain in my heart from my eternity as long as I live in this world. Because I am out of employment more than a year, my mental faculties and conscience are daily swift away from my mind by which I shall afterwards jeopardize my future prospects, subject me to undergo many difficulties, and thereby makes me idle not to provide the necessary expenses of my family but to beg door to door.

“Cares and anorcities are the followers of my un-

fortuation to-days, by which I am as a pilethropic il- (i. e. inner part is empty and outer part shows a very good looking appearance.) Such is my condition.

“So my request to you that your sympathy and philanthropic zeal will take some measure in my part, by provide me a post either by you, or by your direct patronage, to look with a favourable eye towards me by showing some mercy and thankfulness.

“By the pray of the Almighty Father you have placed in a high rank and you have the full capacity to patronize a man like me, which I hope for a long time not to be disappointed, but to remembered me as one of your obedient servant give a sharp reply of this wretched epistle and try for me the last, thereby highly oblige.”

There is such an amusing assumption of self-satisfaction in the following that it also deserves to be quoted :—

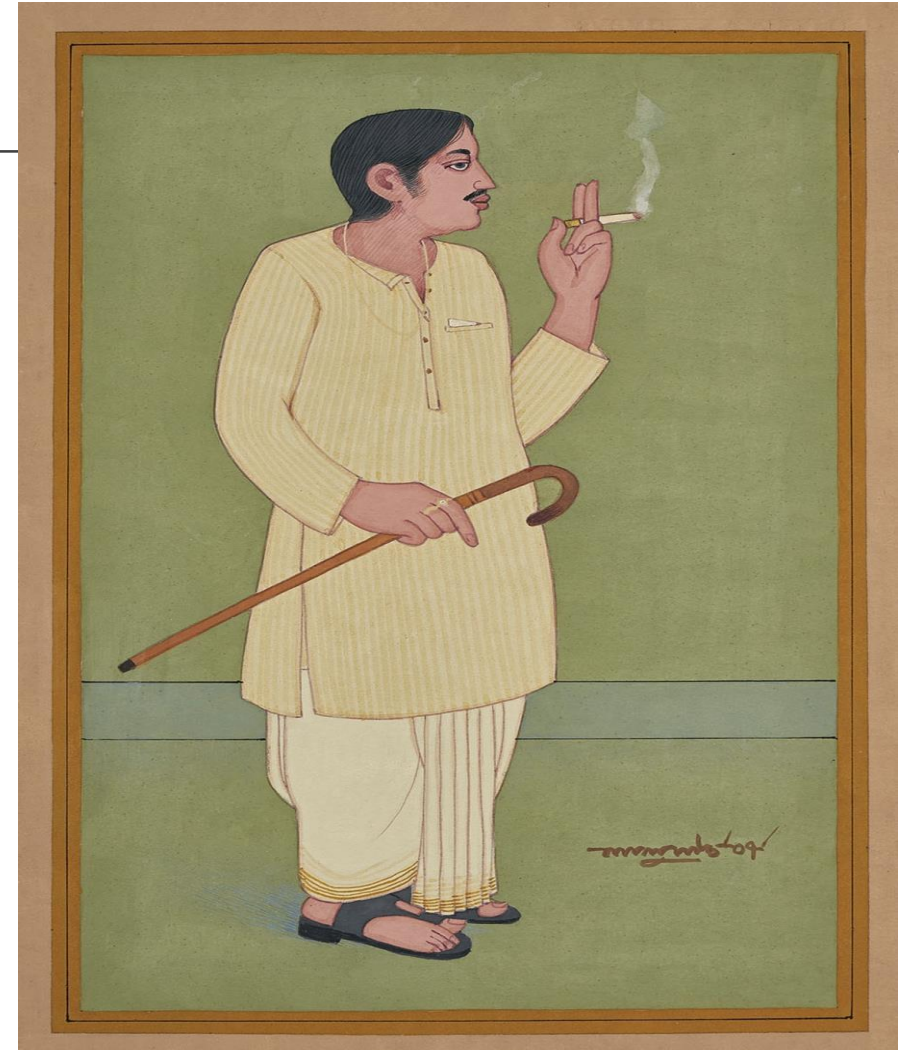
“MOST RESPECTFULLY SHOWETH,—That your petitioner being given to understand that your honor is in want of hands to do the duties of signaller and porters begs to offer himself as a candidate for one of these : that your petitioner can read and write him

Continued

"Sir, Being educated in the Calcutta and by your favour passed B.A. examination I now venture to approach the throne of your goodness... SIR, I am an expert in many things and desire only to be tried to show my agility in mathematics and other languages being hopeful to stand on my own bottom without help..."

Both the Babu and his English were stereotyped and stigmatized by the English.

In British India, babu often referred to a native Indian clerk. The word was originally used as a term of respect attached to a proper name, the equivalent of "mister", and "babuji" was used in many parts to mean "sir" as an address of a gentleman; their life-style was also called "babu culture". They enjoyed a number of privileges for being in the service of the British Raj. The British officials treated them as workers who had both Indian and British connections.



The Beginning of IWE

The period from 1850 to 1900 is **the imitative phase** when the Indian poets mostly wrote romantic poems

They were influenced by the British romantic poets- Wordsworth, Scott, Shelley, Keats, Byron.

The period from 1900-1947 saw mix between romanticism and patriotism in poetry writing

The first phase poets included-Derozio's poems, Kasiprasad Ghose's *The Shair or Minstrel* and other poems, Michael Madhusudan Dutt's *The Captive Lady*, Manmohan Ghose's *Love Songs and Elegies*, Toru Dutt's *Our Casuarina Tree*.

The second phase poets were Sarojini Naidu, Rabindranath Tagore, Aurobindo Ghose and Harindranth Chattopadhyaya.

Continued

The first book written by an Indian in English was *The Travels of Dean Mahomet*. It was a travel narrative by Sake Dean Mahomed, published in England in 1794.

The first Indian novel in English was Bankim Chandra Chatterjee's *Rajmohan's Wife* appeared in 1864. This novel was set in a Bengal village.

Lal Behari Day's *Govinda Samanta* or the *History of a Bengali Raiyat* was published in 1874. His *Folk Tales of Bengal: Life's Secret* was published in 1912.

Bianca, or The Young Spanish Maiden (1878) by Toru Dutt was the first novel written by an Indian woman.

Kisari Mohan Ganguly translated The Mahabharata into English between 1883 and 1896

The history of Anglo-Indian poetry typically begins with Henry L V Derozio. He was generally considered an Anglo-Indian, being of mixed Portuguese, Indian, and English descent, but he considered himself Indian. He was known during his lifetime as the first 'national' poet of modern India. His poems are regarded as an important landmark in the history of patriotic poetry in India, especially "*To India - My Native Land*" and *The Fakeer of Jungheera*. His poems were influenced by Romantic poetry, especially those poets like Lord Byron and Robert Southey.

“To India – My Native Land”

- Henry Louis Vivian Derozio

My country! In thy days of glory past
A beauteous halo circled round thy brow
and worshipped as a deity thou wast—
Where is thy glory, where the reverence now?
Thy eagle pinion is chained down at last,
And grovelling in the lowly dust art thou,
Thy minstrel hath no wreath to weave for thee
Save the sad story of thy misery!
Well—let me dive into the depths of time
And bring from out the ages, that have rolled
A few small fragments of these wrecks sublime
Which human eye may never more behold
And let the guerdon of my labour be,
My fallen country! One kind wish for thee!

Excerpt from Nehru's Autobiography *Toward Freedom* (1936)

In 1920, I was totally ignorant of labour conditions in factories or fields, and my political outlook was entirely bourgeois.... I knew, of course, that there was terrible poverty and misery... Just then, I got entangled in the kisan movement. Early in June 1920 (as far as I can remember), about 200 kisans marched fifty miles from the interior of Partabgarh district to Allahabad city with the intention of drawing the attention of the prominent politicians there to their woebegone condition... accompanied by some friends, I went to see them. They told us of the crushing exactions of the talukdars, of inhuman treatment, and that their condition had become wholly intolerable. They begged us to accompany them ... to protect them from the vengeance of the talukdars, who were angry at their having come to Allahabad on this mission.

The visit was a revelation to me. We found the whole countryside afire with enthusiasm and full of a strange excitement. Enormous gatherings would take place at the briefest notice by word of mouth. One village would communicate with another, and the second with the third, and so on; and presently whole villages would empty out, and all over the fields there would be men and women and children on the march to the meeting place.

Impact of English Education

The young Indians with proper education were able to read, write and speak English with competence.

They learned and acquired the language of power

It made great impact on the social, political and the religious life of India.

For the very first time, Indians became critical about both their own religious orthodoxies such as polygamy, the system of child marriages, superstitions, casteism, poverty, illiteracy and at the same time, they were critical about the British rule.

In spite of its diverse cultures, races and religions Indian Writing in English has successfully recaptured and reflected the multi-cultural, multi-lingual society.

Once Indians became familiar with the English language they increasingly used it for utilitarian communication. They started making use of it for creative purposes as well- essays, speeches, travelogues, letters, biographies, autobiographies, verse, drama, story, etc.

Writing Back

Indian English has become the language in which India converses regularly

Indian writing in English has gradually and increasingly grown to become a new form of every Indian culture and the voice that articulates the thoughts, passions and dreams of countless Indians

These writings show how the colonial encounter has (consciously and subconsciously) influenced them to use the western genre of the autobiography/travel writing form to write back to the Empire.

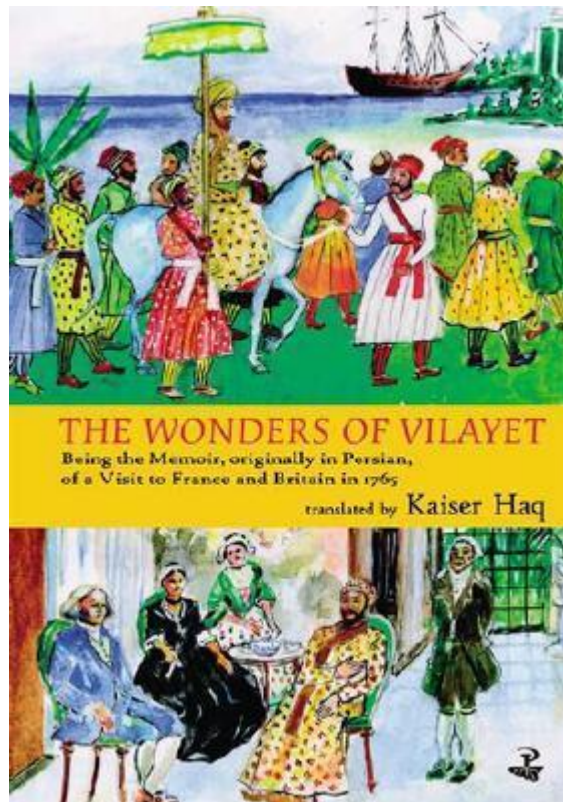
Helps to understand how the East has interpreted the West and has been able to legitimize itself by writing back to it in an alien tongue (English language).

Continued

The late 18th, 19th and early 20th century IWE majorly focused on non-fictional prose-works, consisting of letters, diaries, political manifesto, articles, speeches, philosophical works etc.

Travel Writing was also one of the many forms that became popular-

1. **Mirza Sheik I'tesamuddin's *The Wonders of Vilayet*** was published in 1784. He was a Bengali diplomat for the Mughal Empire and the first educated South Asian to travel to Europe, in 1765. He was also a munshi serving the Nawabs of Bengal as well as the British East India Company.
2. **Trilokyanath Mukhopadhyay** was an Indian civil servant who served as a curator of the Indian Museum at Calcutta. He was a renowned author who wrote both in English and Bengali. He was in-charge of organizing exhibits for the Calcutta International Exhibition of 1883, the Amsterdam Exhibition in the same year, the 1886 Colonial and Indian Exhibition, and the 1888 Glasgow International Exhibition. His travels in Europe was published as a popular travelogue ***A Visit to Europe (1889)***.
3. **Romesh Chunder Dutt's *Three Years in Europe, 1868 to 1871 (1896)***
4. The Maharani of Cooch Behar, **Suniti Devi's *The Autobiography of an Indian Princess (1921)***. Suniti Devi was an educationist and a woman's rights activist.



A VISIT TO EUROPE

BY
T. N. MUKHARJI

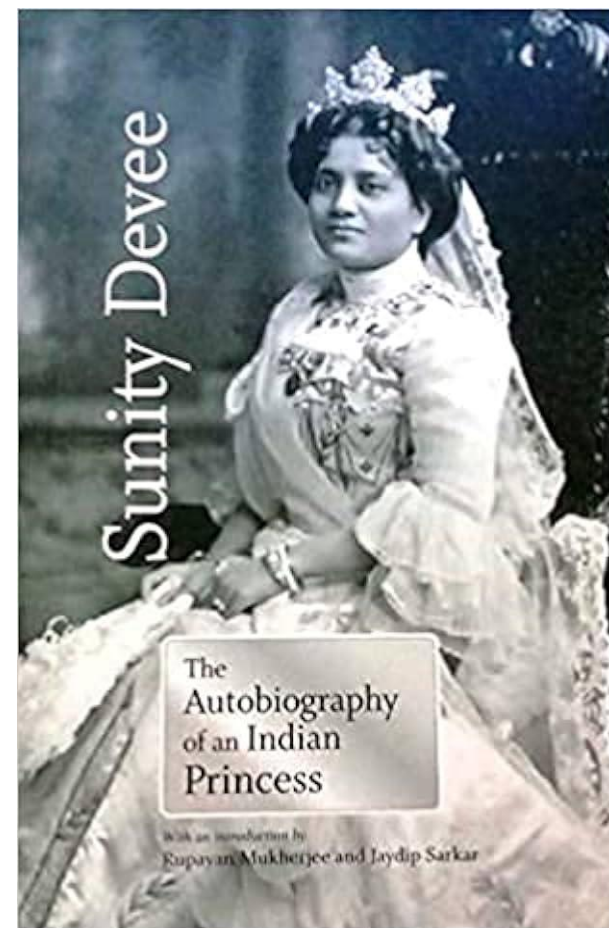
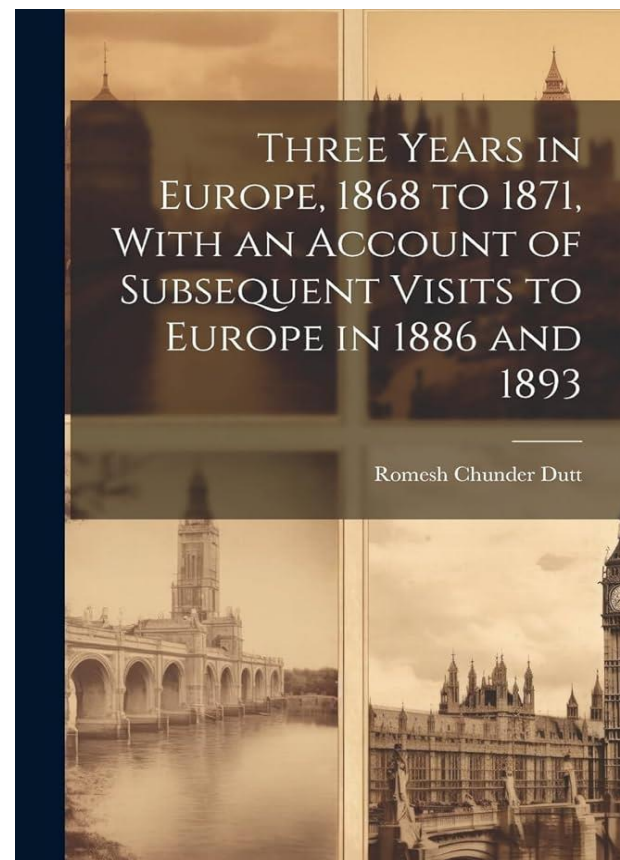
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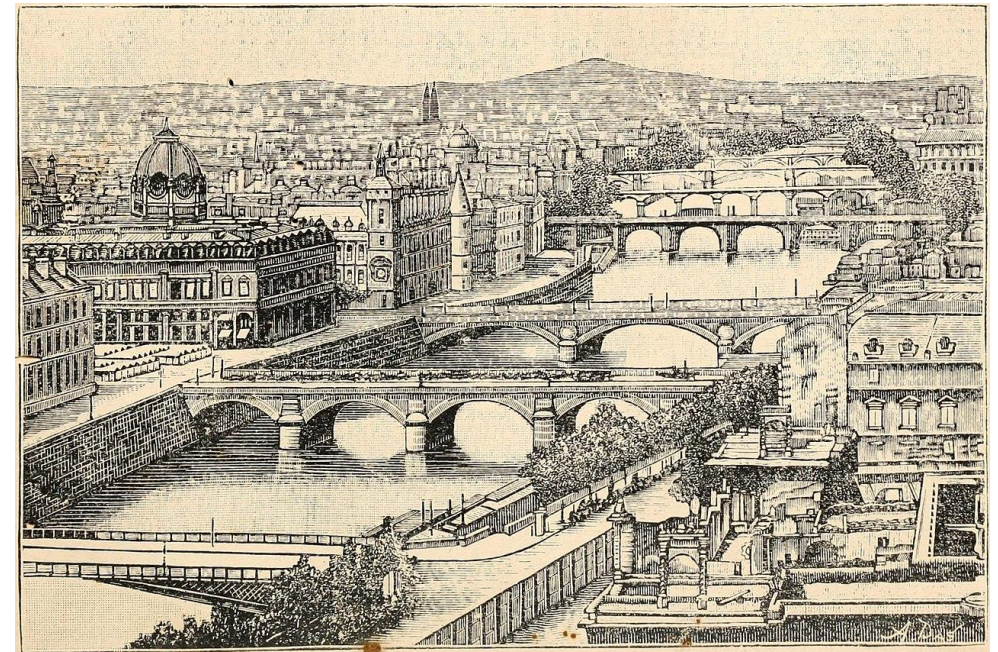
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Three Years in Europe, 1868 to 1871 by Romesh Chunder Dutt

THERE is but one Paris in the world,—and that is Paris! It would be difficult in any other part of the world to find such a crowd of public monuments and magnificent public buildings and fine specimens of architecture. It would be difficult to match her splendid Boulevards with spacious footpaths and fine rows of trees, and brilliantly lighted cafés on either side, thronged with people until midnight! The Bois de Boulogne is a perfect forest turned into a Park! The limpid Seine with her numerous bridges is a perfect picture, seen from any eminence. And as the visitor standing on such eminence surveys the whole town of Paris under his feet—surveys on the south of the Seine the double tower of Notre Dame, the domes of the Pantheon and the Sorbonne, the gilded spire of La Chapelle, and the gilded dome of the Hotel des Invalides—as he runs his eye towards the west over the Arc de Triomphe and the twelve beautiful avenues stretching in different directions from the Arc,—as he admires the Champs Elysé, the Place de la Concorde, the gardens of the Tuileries, and the magnificent palace of Louvre, all in one line along the north bank of the Seine,—and as he sees a forest of beautiful houses and fine streets stretching far away from that river to the north, as far as the heights of Montmatre and La Villette,—he can scarcely believe that so lovely a picture is not the vision of a dream, that a view so noble and so perfect can be a busy crowded city, the centre of busy traffic, and swarming with two millions of busy, hard-working men and women!



Gandhi and Nehru

Mohandas Karamchand Gandhi was a Barrister, Writer, Freedom fighter. He was one of the first generation of Indians to study in England, one of the first nationalists to use the language of Imperialism to challenge the Imperial regime, Father of the Nation.

Jawaharlal Nehru was a Lawyer, Writer, Prime Minister. He was educated in Harrow and Cambridge, a Socialist by temperament, First Prime Minister of Independent India.

England becomes a metaphor for nationalism in both the writers.

Gandhi's *My Experiments with Truth* (1927) and Nehru's *Autobiography* (1936) showed:

- People during the Raj days went to England to earn a degree that could make their lives better back home. A 'Made-in-England' tag was the magic mantra to survive in colonial India.
- An English education and exposure to the English way of life would also enable them to fight colonial imperialism. They acted as interpreters of the alien tongue and Indianised the language of the white rulers

The Indian Novel

The beginning of the twentieth century saw a gradual growth of the novel form in English in India.

Romesh Chandra Dutt was an important figure writing at that time. He occupied important Government posts before retiring as the Diwan of the Royal Baroda State. He wrote six novels in Bengali, out of which two he translated into English: *The Lake of Palms* (1902) and *The Slave Girl of Agra* (1909). Both these novels were published in London and were hailed as writings with dense plots and vivid characterization.

Other writers of this era are: T. Ramakrishna who wrote *Dive for Death* and Swarna Ghoshal who wrote *The Fatal Garland*. Krupabai Sathianandan wrote *Kamala, A Story of Hindu Life* (1894) Bal Krishna, *The Love of Kusama* (1910), Sir Joginder Singh, *Nasrin* (1915), Rajam Iyer, *Vasudeo Shastri* (1905) and A. Madhavan in *Thillai Gobindan* (1916).

Rabindranath Tagore (1861–1941)

Was a Bengali polymath – poet, writer, playwright, composer, philosopher, social reformer and painter

A visionary, he founded the Visva- Bharati University which became known as the model of Education.

The *Home and the World* (1919), *The Wreck* (1921) and *Gora* (1923) have all been translated from Bengali to English.

His *Gitanjali* made Tagore a world literary figure winning him the highest honour- the Nobel Prize in Literature, 1913

Nirad C Chaudhuri

Nirad. C. Chaudhuri was a Novelist, Critic, Essayist. He is known as an Anglophile and Indophobe

Chaudhuri's book *A Passage to England* (1959) is an example of post-colonial encounter. It reinforces his pro-English views.

His idea of England is the 'fairytale England'. For him fantasy becomes reality when he sets his eyes on England.

It is a merger of two ethoses- the 18th-century English values of order, precision, stability coupled with the prim and proper decorum of Victoria's England.

The travelogue gives us a fascinating idea of England.

The Trinity of IWE

Mulk Raj Anand, R. K. Narayan and Raja Rao became the trinity of Indian writing in English.

Speaking of The Big Three, William Walsh said: “It is these three writers who defined the area in which the Indian novel was to operate. They established its assumptions; they sketched its main themes, freed the first models of its characters and elaborated its particular logic. Each of them used an easy, natural idiom which was unaffected by the opacity of a British inheritance. Their language has been freed of the foggy taste of Britain and transferred to a wholly new setting of brutal heat and brilliant light.”

‘Stylistic influence’ from the local languages appears to be an exceptional feature of much of the Indian literature in English - the local language construction and system is very much reflected in the illustrations, as is mirrored in the literal translation of local idioms.

One more seminal feature of English Indian writers is that they have not only ‘nativised’ the ‘British mother tongue’ in terms of stylistic features, but, they have also acculturated English in terms of the ‘Indianised context’.

Continued

Mulk Raj Anand (1905–2004) was similarly gaining recognition for his writing set in rural India, but his stories were harsher, and engaged, sometimes brutally, with divisions of caste, class and religion. *Untouchable* (1935), *The Village* (1939), *Across the Back Waters* (1939) and *The Sword and the Sickle* (1942) are some of his notable works in English.

R. K. Narayan (1906–2001) contributed over many decades and continued to write till his death. His evocation of small town life and its experiences through the eyes of the endearing child protagonist Swaminathan in *Swami and Friends* (1935) is a good sample of his writing style. His travelogue *My Dateless Diary* (1960), his autobiography *My Days* (1973), his novels *The Bachelor of Arts* (1937), *The English Teacher* (1945), *Guide* (1958), etc., shaped IWE to a great extent.

Raja Rao (1908–2006) an Indian philosopher and writer, authored *Kanthapura* (1938) and *The Serpent and the Rope* (1960), *The Cat and Shakespeare* (1965) and *Comrade Kirrilov* (1976) and *The Cow of the Barricades* (1947- short story collection) exhibited Indian story telling qualities.

Continued

The whole body of Indian novel in English may be divided into three broad groups:

- a) The traditional novel of social realism before Independence.
- b) The modern novel of experimentation after Independence.
- c) A new contemporary novel since 1981.

Indian Writers in English

According to K. R. S. Iyengar, there are three types of Indian Writers in English. “First, those who have acquired their entire education in English schools and universities. Second, Indians who have settled abroad, but are constantly in touch with the changing surroundings and traditions of their country of adoption. And finally, Indians who have acquired English as a second language.”

Thus a large number of Indians were guided by the genuine desire to present before the western readers an authentic picture of India through their writings.

The Indian Writers in English brought out through their writings a ‘Bharat Brand of English’ as said by R.K. Narayan. He did not support “mongrelisation” or the hybridization of English. Narayan believed that Indian English should have its own distinct identity, a “Swadeshi Stamp” He hoped that Indians build their own English that is more original and distinct than current English.

Contemporary IWE

Among the later writers, the most notable is **Salman Rushdie**, born in India and now living in the USA.

His work *Midnight's Children* (Booker Prize 1981, Booker of Bookers 1992, and Best of the Bookers 2008), ushered in a new trend of writing. He used a hybrid language – English generously peppered with Indian terms – to convey a theme that could be seen as representing the vast canvas of India.

Nayantara Sehgal was one of the first female Indian writers in English to receive wide recognition. Her fiction deals with India's elite responding to the crises engendered by political change. She was awarded the 1986 Sahitya Akademi Award for English, for her novel, *Rich Like Us* (1985), by the Sahitya Akademi, India's National Academy of Letters.

She is the daughter of Vijaya Lakshmi Pandit, the sister of Pandit Jawaharlal Nehru. She mainly wrote on topics related to politics and feminism.

Continued

Anita Desai, who was shortlisted for the Booker Prize three times, received a Sahitya Akademi Award in 1978 for her novel *Fire on the Mountain* and a British Guardian Prize for *The Village by the Sea*. Her daughter Kiran Desai won the 2006 Man Booker Prize for her second novel, *The Inheritance of Loss*.

Ruskin Bond received Sahitya Akademi Award for his collection of short stories *Our Trees Still Grow in Dehra* in 1992. He is also the author of a historical novel *A Flight of Pigeons*, which is based on an episode during the Indian Rebellion of 1857.

Vikram Seth, author of *The Golden Gate* (1986), *A Suitable Boy* (1994), *An Unequal Music* (1999) is a writer who uses a purer English and more realistic themes.

Prafulla Mohanti

Prafulla Mohanti is an Architect and Artist. He is also an internationally known Town Planner, Painter, Novelist, Social Worker.

His *Through Brown Eyes* (1985) is a collage of many ideas of England.

It is a collection of experiences- from fancy to despondency to reconciliation and finally understanding.

The book blends admiration with resentment , acceptance with rejection.

Traces of ambivalence along with doses of nostalgia are present in the novel. Thus the identity crisis reaches its peak here.

The book traces the darker aspects of the West- its racial intolerance, the angst of being alienated in a foreign land and the nostalgia that grips a lonely immigrant.

It is the brown man's idea of England.

What makes IWE Indian?

Raja Rao says in the preface of his novel *Kanthapura*: “*One has to convey in a language that is not one’s own, the spirit that is one’s own.*”

K. R. Srinivasa Iyengar has rightly commented in this regard: “What makes Indo-Anglian literature an Indian literature and not just a ramshackle outhouse of English literature is the quality of its ‘Indianness’ in the choice of its subjects, in the texture of thought and play of sentiment, in the organisation of material and in the creative use of language.”

Meenakshi Mukherjee observes: “Whatever be the language in which it is written, a novel by an Indian writer demands direct involvement in values and experiences which are valid in the Indian context.”

IWE represents the shared consciousness, ethos, tradition, cultural experiences and heritage of India and Indians. It represented and reflected the Indian sensibility in all forms of writings- essay, novel, non-fiction, poetry, drama, etc.

Characteristics of IWE

Reflects the complicacies of Indian life

Plural in make up and style

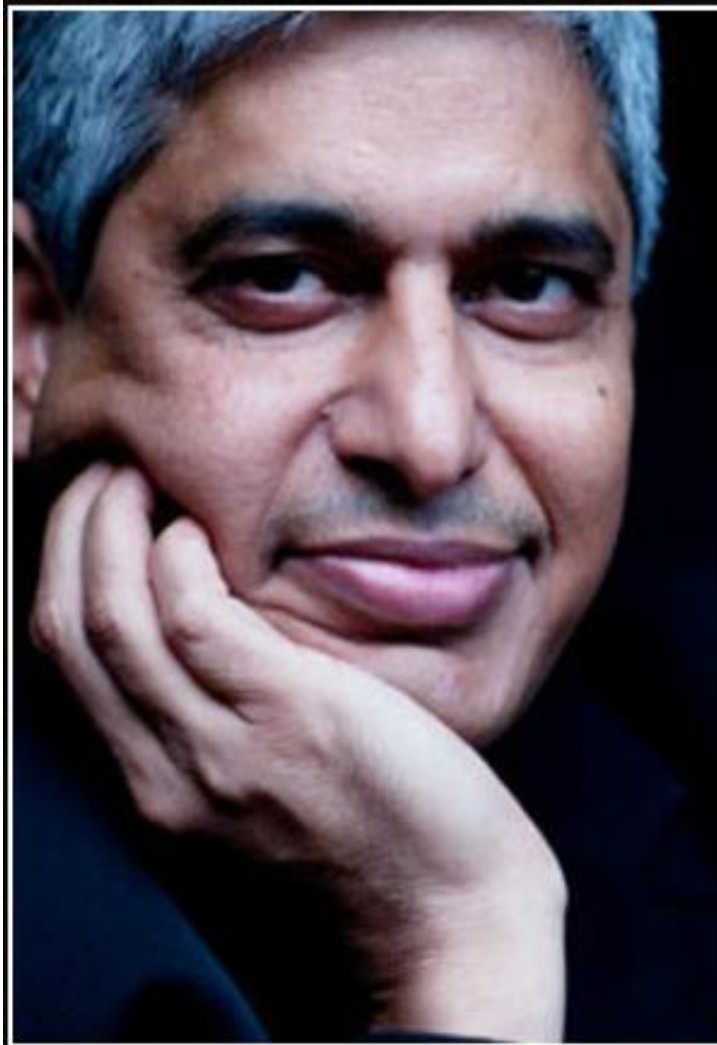
Delicacy, nuanced and irony

Non linear (many dimensional) narrative

Hybridity

Amit Chaudhuri (a novelist, poet, essayist, literary critic, editor, singer, and music composer from India), says that these themes present the microcosms of India that supposedly reflect Indian conditions. He contrasts this with the works of earlier writers such as Narayan where the use of English is pure, but the deciphering of meaning needs cultural familiarity.

He also feels that Indianness is a theme constructed only in IWE and does not articulate itself in the vernacular literatures. He further adds "the post-colonial novel, becomes a trope for an ideal hybridity by which the West celebrates not so much Indianness, whatever that infinitely complex thing is, but its own historical quest, its reinterpretation of itself".



Indian writers have appropriated
English as an Indian language, and
that gives a certain freshness to the
way we write.

— *Vikas Swarup* —

AZ QUOTES

Contemporary IWE Features & Influences

As colonies liberated themselves, new national formations had to negotiate a mix of local identity, residual colonial traits, and new forces of global power.

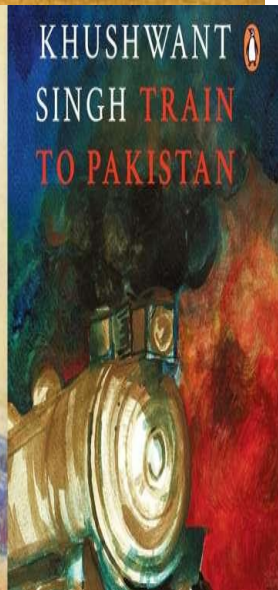
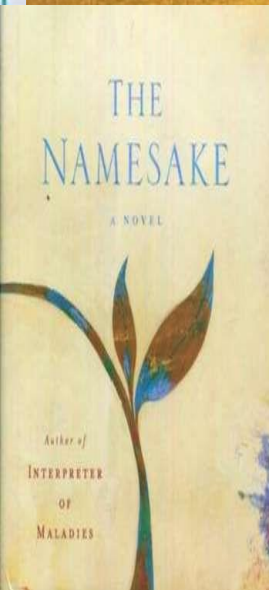
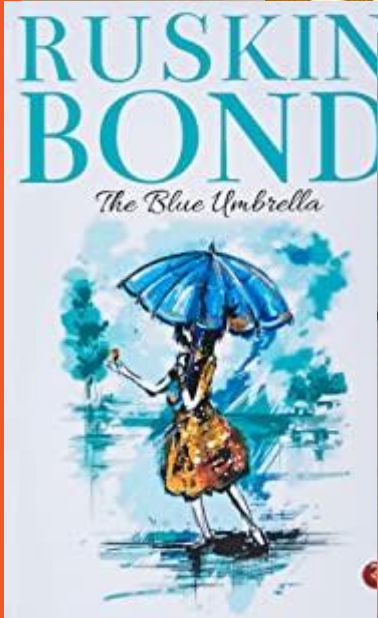
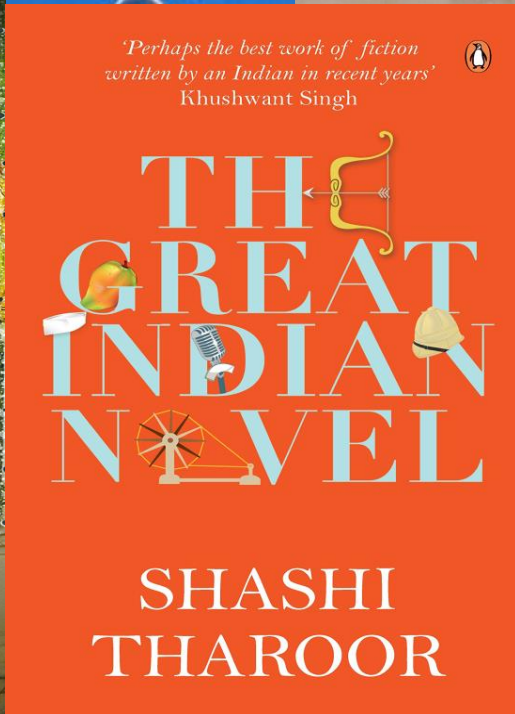
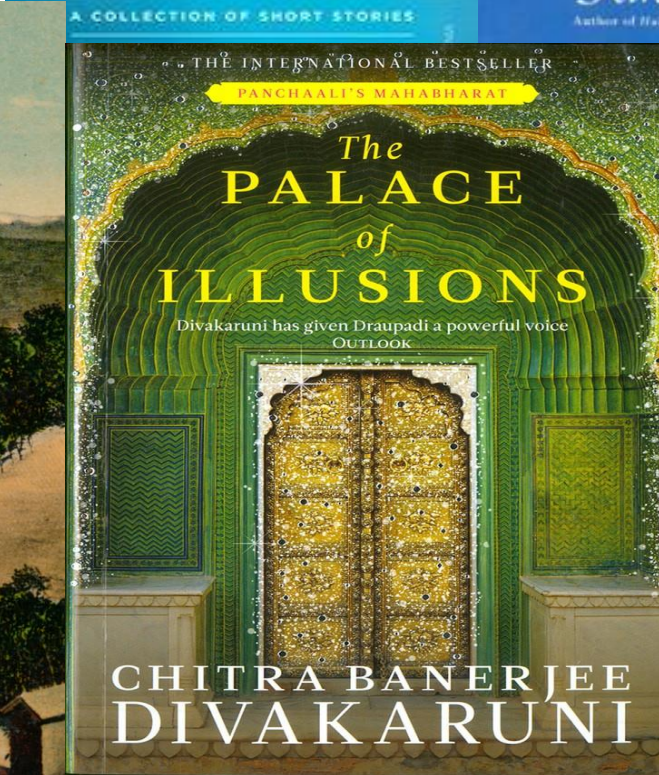
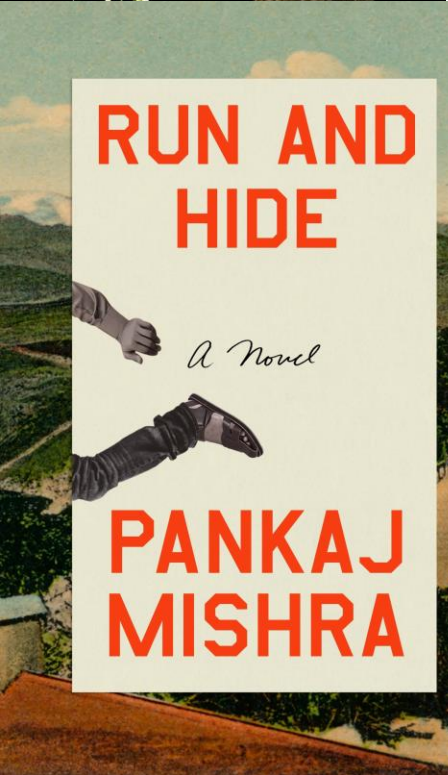
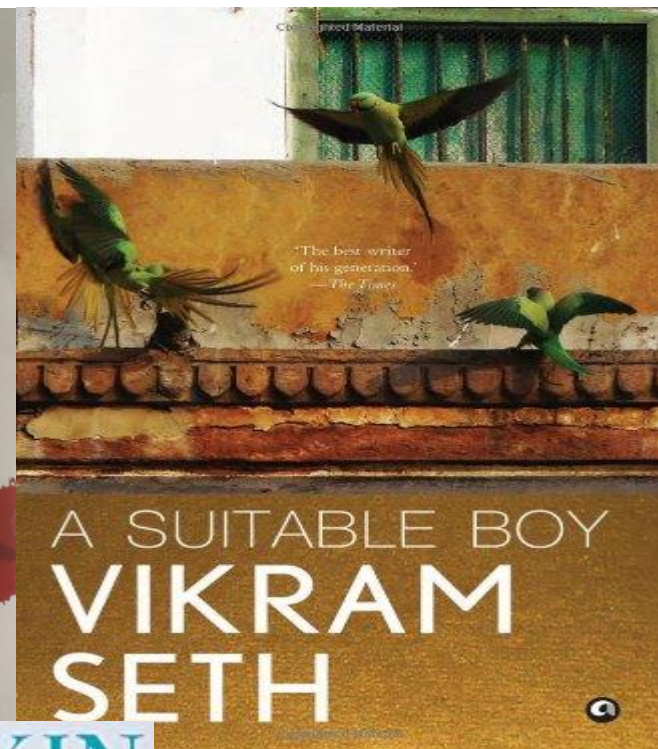
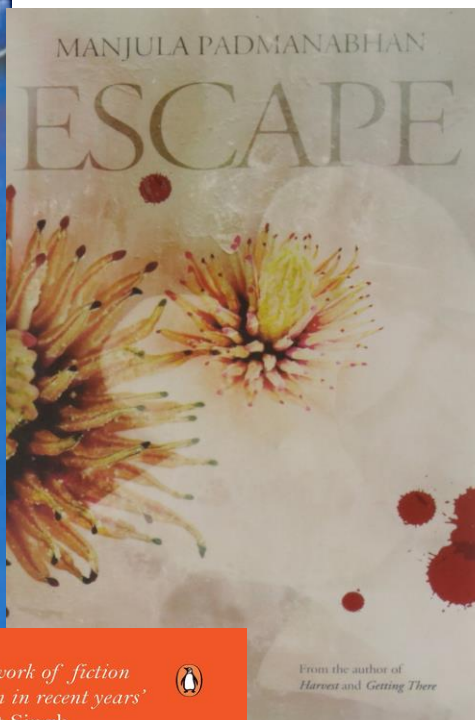
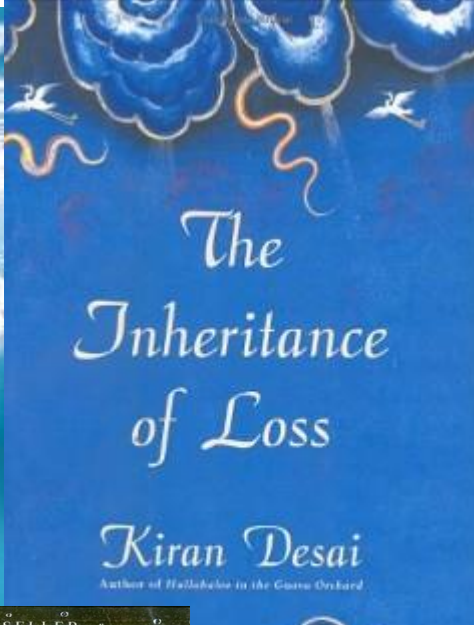
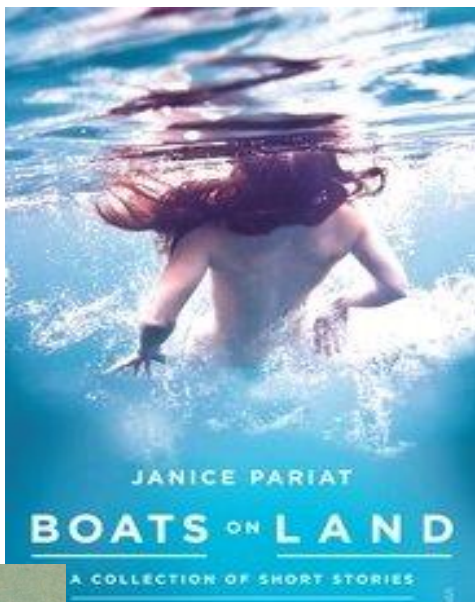
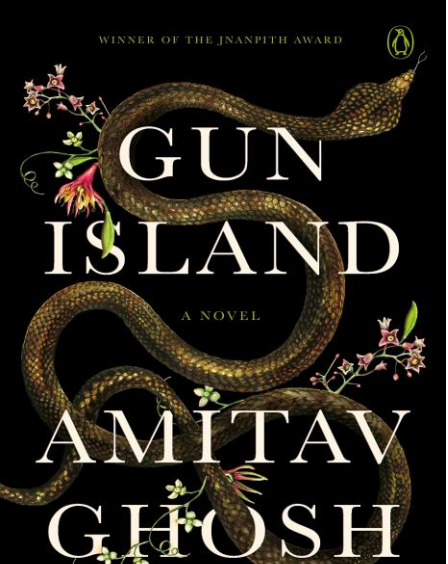
New and more complex cosmopolitan identities had to be discovered, and writers and texts reflecting these became correspondingly more problematic to assess, as old centralisms gave way to new networks of cultural control.

The degree of creativity increased phenomenally due to globalization.

The writers became very cosmopolitan in their representation of India and Indianness

Their works contemplated and deliberated on multifarious range of issues like nationalism, freedom struggle, social realism, individual consciousness, changing society, and the like.

The horrors, tragic consequences and partition like the large scale migration, reckless looting and merciless massacres were portrayed by the writers in their works which captured the interest, and imagination of the reader, the Indian English novels began to prove its mark in the global literary scenario. East – West conflict, multi – culturalism, social realism, gender issues, comic aspect of human nature, ecological concerns, magic realism, diasporic writings and the like became the themes of the post – Independent writers.



Changes in IWE

The stalwarts of the Indian writing like R.K. Narayan, Mulk Raj Anand, and their ilk promoted the conventional mode of writing in English.

The contemporary and modern era writers like Salman Rushdie, Amitav Ghosh, Vikram Seth, Upamanyu Chatterjee, etc., elucidated and substantiated strength of the emerging modern voice of India.

The sudden spirit of creative writing in the eighties reflects the sense of awareness of the plurality of the nation. It transcends the east – west conflict and portrays the new Post Colonial India with its evolving outlook, which is essentially a blend of tradition and modernism. It reveals the cosmopolitan outlook of the new generation who strives to strike a balance between the inherited traditional values and imbibed foreign culture. The treatment and technique of the novel is Trans-national and Trans – continental.

The contemporary post – colonial writers like Rushdie, Rohinton Mistry, Arundhati Roy, Meena Alexander, Anita Nair and Jhumpa Lahiri have initiated the process of decolonizing the ‘Colonial English’ and using it as a medium to express Indian thoughts and sensibilities with a distinctive Indian style.

Postcolonial IWE

It describes many interactions between 'coloniser' and 'colonised.'

The British Empire consisted of more than a quarter of all the territory on the surface of the earth: one in four people was a subject of Queen Victoria. **It is the literature and the art produced in the countries such as India, Sri Lanka, Nigeria, Senegal and Australia after their independence, called Postcolonial literature.**

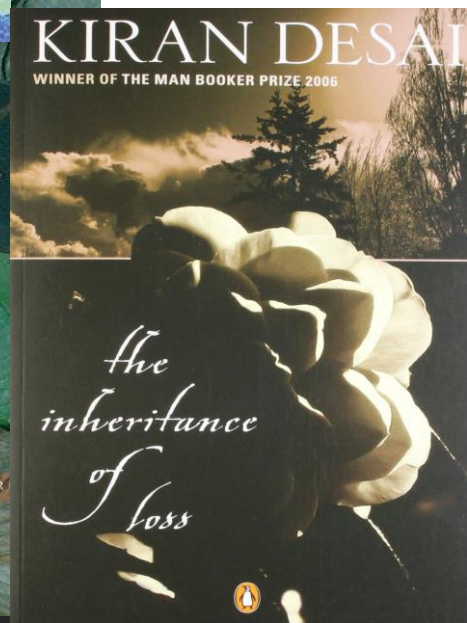
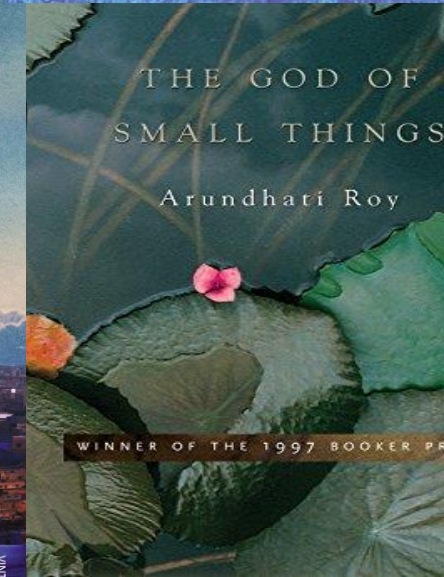
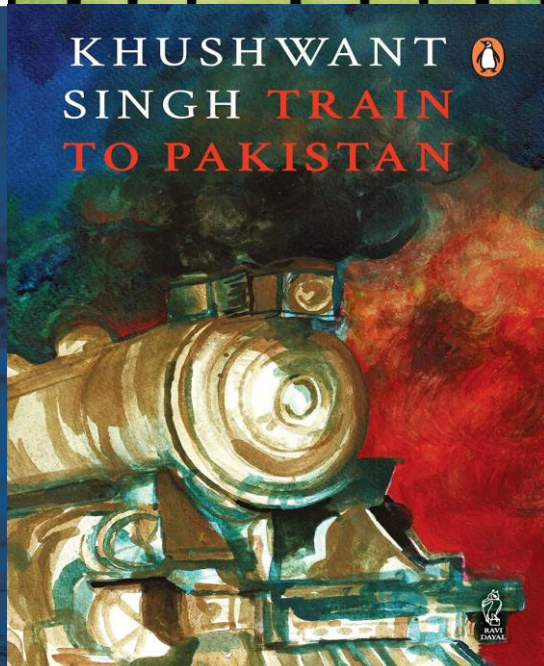
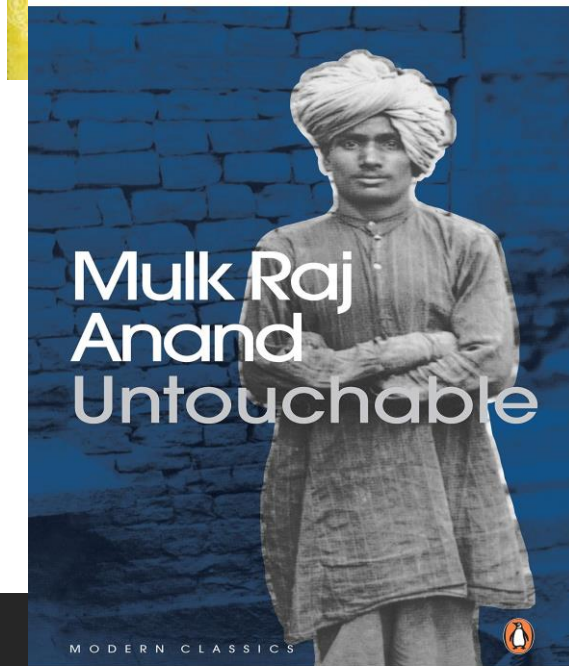
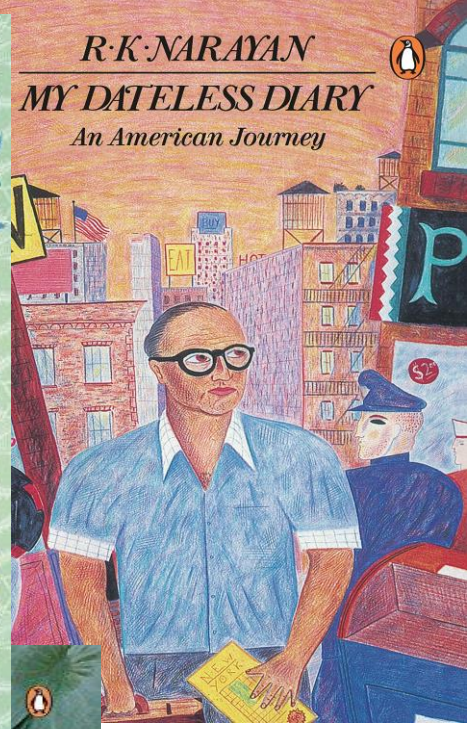
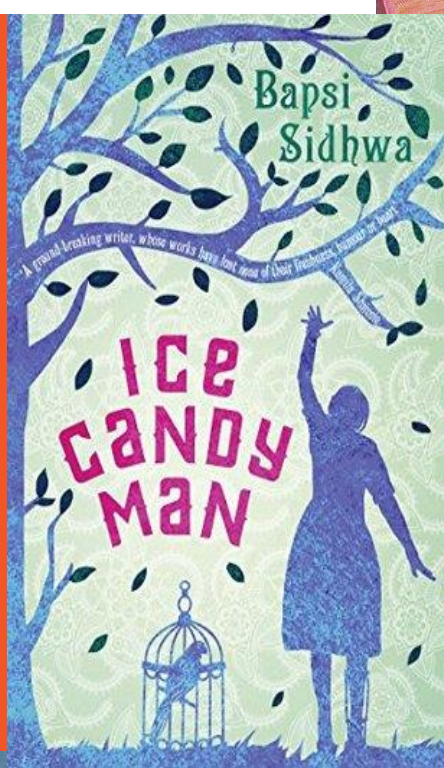
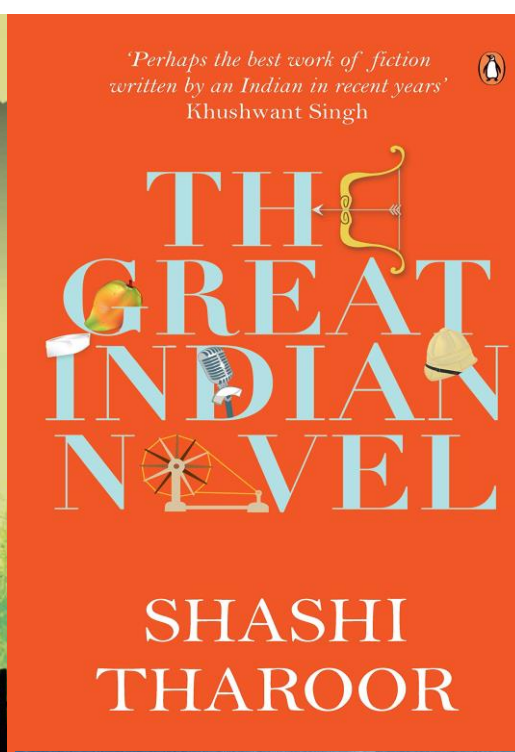
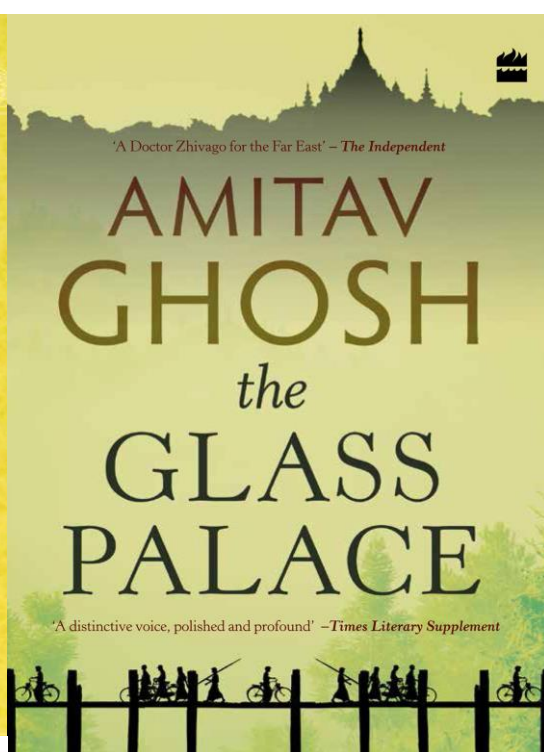
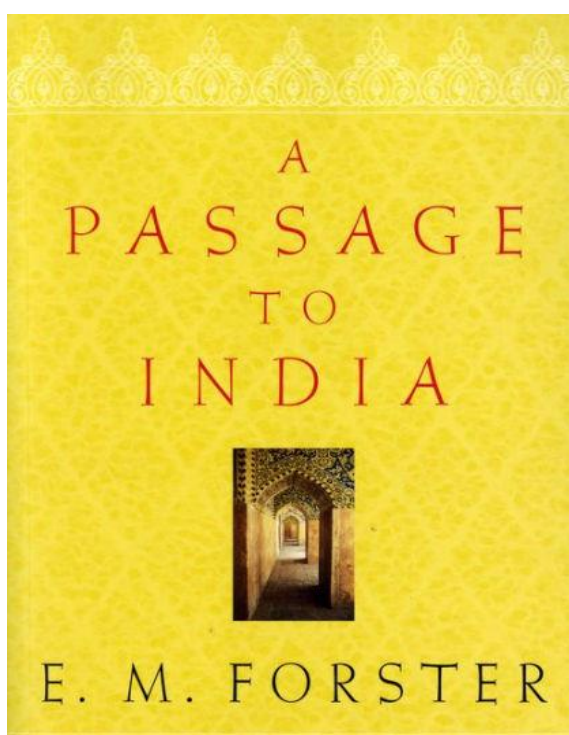
Edward Said's prominent book 'Orientalism' is an assessment of Western representation of the Eastern culture under the label 'Postcolonial Studies'.

Postcolonial novels are rooted in the liberal middle class conscience

Postcolonial writing involves around: migration, slavery, suppression, resistance, representation, difference, race, gender, place and responses to these.

The writers also dealt with a variety of sub-themes such as 'rootlessness', 'alienation', 'gender discrimination', 'labour exploitation', 'hybridity', 'poverty', 'corruption', 'marginalism' and so on.

Reinterpreting India for the west



Some Examples

Arundhati Roy came to limelight by the publication of her first novel, "The God of Small Things" (1997) because of its unique narrative techniques and the powerful use of the language with a tinge of her native Malayalam. The God of Small Things also won the Booker Prize for English Fiction. Her non fiction works also deal with unorthodox thoughts about freedom and equal rights irrespective of sex, colour, and social status.

Kiran Desai, daughter of Anita Desai, had won the Booker Prize for her second novel, "The Inheritance Of Loss" in 2006. "The Inheritance of Loss" deals with a number of themes- the beauty of rustic life to identity crisis, pangs of insurgency and immigration. The character of Jemubhai Patel represents the transitions of India from a colony to an independent nation.

Aravind Adiga won Booker Prize for literature in 2008 for "The White Tiger"- its narrative strategy and realistic presentation of the world of corruption prevalent in all realms of Indian life. Known for its authenticity of voicing the problems and changes of the Third World, many of the situations in the novel have parallels with the contemporary Indian events.

Continued

Anita Desai, an eminent novelist is known for her in depth analysis of human mind and its working. Desai's novels express feminine sensibility to a great extent. She reveals the unfathomable depth of human mind. Her writings depict the plight of isolated human being who are sidelined and cut off from the main streams of life. *Cry, the Peacock (1963)* is considered as her masterpiece.

Vikram Seth is an internationally known novelist and poet. His *A Suitable Boy (1993)* deals with harsh realities of post independent India in all its manifestations. Vikram Seth's works transcends the narrow national boundaries and stands for world citizenship as like the writer himself. He has received several awards such as **Padma Shri, Sahitya Academy Award, Pravasi Bharatiya Samman, WH Smith Literary Award** and **Crossword Book Award**.

Manohar Malgonkar is a famous Indian novelist. His works experiment with history in fictional terms. Malgonkar's novels are a mixture of intrigue, suspense and love in its crude form. *A Bend in the Ganges (1964)* deals with the second world war and its impact on man and nature.

Chetan Bhagat is one of the most representative writers of contemporary India. His books deal with corruption, nepotism, changes in relationships among the Indian youth, the rise of corporate culture in India, cross cultural relationships, etc.

Continued

Amitav Ghosh is an Indian writer and the winner of the 54th Jnanpith award, India's highest literary honor, best known for his work in English fiction.

Ghosh's ambitious novels use complex narrative strategies to probe the nature of national and personal identity, particularly of the people of India and Southeast Asia.

His famous Ibis trilogy is a work of historical fiction. The story is set in the first half of the 19th century. It deals with the trade of opium between India and China run by the East India Company and the trafficking of coolies to Mauritius. It comprises *Sea of Poppies* (2008), *River of Smoke* (2011), and *Flood of Fire* (2015).

His *The Shadow Lines* (1988) that won him the **Sahitya Akademi Award** "throws light on the phenomenon of communal violence and the way its roots have spread deeply and widely in the collective psyche of the Indian subcontinent"; *The Glass Palace* (2000) deals with colonial history; Ghosh's most recent book, *Gun Island* (2019) deals with climate change, human migration and global politics.

His non-fictions like *In an Antique Land* (1992), *Dancing in Cambodia and At Large in Burma* (1998), *Countdown* (1999), and *The Imam and the Indian* (2002) are based on themes such as fundamentalism, the history of the novel, Egyptian culture, and literature. His latest, *The Great Derangement: Climate Change and the Unthinkable* (2016) addresses issues of climate change, and how radical transformation due to nature has become 'unthinkable'.

Continued

Rohinton Mistry is an Indian-born Canadian writer. He has been the recipient of many awards including the Neustadt International Prize for Literature in 2012. Both of his first two novels were shortlisted for the Booker Prize. His novels to date have been set in India, told from the perspective of Parsis, and explore themes of family life, poverty, discrimination, and the corrupting influence of society. *Such a Long Journey* (1991), *A Fine Balance* (1995) is set in "an unidentified city" in India, initially in 1975 and later in 1984 during the turmoil of The Emergency and *Family Matters* (2002)- is set in the 1990s Shiv Sena-ruled Bombay.

Easterine Kire is a poet and author who currently lives in northern Norway. The majority of her writings are based in the lived realities of the people in Nagaland in north-east India. Her motivation to write is summed up in this statement by her in an interview, "I felt we needed to create written Naga Literature. We have so much oral narratives but with oral dying out, it's all going to be lost." Easterine Kire's *Son of the Thundercloud* has been awarded Bal Sahitya Puraskar by Sahitya Academy in 2018. In 2011, she was awarded the Governor's Medal for excellence in Naga literature and the Free Voice Award by Catalan PEN Barcelona. *Bitter Wormwood* was shortlisted for The Hindu Prize in 2013. *A Terrible Matriarchy* was selected to be translated into UN languages. In 2015, her *When the River Sleeps* was awarded The Hindu Literary Prize.

To Conclude

Founded on liberal humanist verities (qualities)- timeless significance, socio-political, literary-historical, autobiographical, unchanging human nature, multiculturalism, individuality, realistic, authenticity, sincerity, etc.

Indian as a hybrid entity

East - West conflict, multi-culturalism, social realism, gender issues, comic aspect of human nature, ecological concerns, magic realism, diasporic writings and the like.

English is increasingly being used by writers to give shape to the conflicting dilemmas and issues that confront the human psyche.

Industrialisation, urbanization, globalization, modernization and feminism and women's empowerment and the changing social dynamics constitute the major themes of the modern Indian English writers.

Thank You

"The most distinguishing feature of Indian writing in English is that it has acquired a certain self-confidence as a genre because there is a whole generation for whom there is no need to feel self-conscious about the use of this language or the kind of stories we tell in it."

~~ Shashi Tharoor